during the day, and since the academy was about ‘all for one, one for all’, all of us were called for a punishment parade. Introductions began with us —the first-termers—in high-plank position. Some of us couldn’t even remain in the position for thirty seconds. Whenever one of us fell flat on the floor, the others were asked by the seniors to do more push-ups. Punishments in the academy were commonly known as ‘ragda’. And we were undergoing our first ragda on our first day. This was just one of the numerous punishments the seniors would give us until we became seniors the following term ourselves. And that’s when we would do the same to our juniors. Thus, the cycle would go on.

‘Why is your hair not in place?’ asked a senior flight cadet, Sonia, as I struggled to keep myself in the plank position. I did not know how to respond and stayed quiet.

‘I’m asking you,’ she bent forward and said.

‘I . . . I tried my best, Ma’am,’ I said, stuttering. I had applied enough oil and had tied my hair into a tight bun, so why was I being checked? She pulled a strand out of my bun and asked, ‘Is this your best?’ And then she shouted loudly into my ear, ‘It’s not TIGHT ENOUGH!’ I flinched. ‘And you have the guts to answer back?’ she shouted angrily. ‘Get up, you lazy fools. Run to your cabins and get your oil bottles. We’ll teach you how to make a bun.’

And this is how I was introduced to my first ‘oil parade’ in the academy. It was one of the most common punishments, in which the flight cadets were made to oil their hair until oil dripped on their foreheads and faces. Some other punishments, included drinking mugs of water from a half-filled bucket and then spinning around until they threw up, only to roll around in each other’s vomit—front rolls, back rolls, crawling, legs up against the wall and anything else that could be physically and mentally excruciating. As first-termers, we were most prone to making small mistakes and so, punishments were given all through the day and the night. This included both official punishments by instructors and unofficial punishments by seniors. There was no time for rest and respite. Strict